

Niche Ecommerce Opportunity Report

Product-first research across five research rounds · Around 60 product angles investigated, 80+ live Google UK page-1 checks, 60+ off-SERP UK suppliers named · August 2026

The 30-second version

Ideas were generated two ways: from how supply chains are organised (unbundled parts, trade-gated products, byproducts) and from mapping the pursuits of high earners (the golf-weights, speciality-coffee and raw-dog-food buyer). Each idea then faced three gates: a live page-1 shelf test, a named UK supplier who is not already retailing, and a test costing well under £2,000. Roughly three quarters of everything investigated is already occupied, often by specialists that did not exist three years ago. What survived is below, each with an ad-campaign test specified so nothing gets built on guesswork.

#	Opportunity	Why it survived	First test
1	Garden putting green DIY kits Surface + regulation cups + flags + fringe + edging, in three sizes	Nobody in the UK sells the kit people search for. Google substitutes £3k-15k installer services, bare turf rolls, indoor mats and a US kit maker (XGrass) that does not ship here. UK trade turf manufacturers sit off-SERP. Same buyer and psychology as golf weights.	£300 ads on 'putting green kit uk' to a kit-configurator page
2	Natural swimming pond kits Box-welded liner + filtration + regeneration-zone plant packs, staged from a £99-299 planning pack up to £3k-8k component kits	One weak UK specialist across all queries; otherwise installers, a DIY course, YouTube and a US brand. The German category giant (NaturaGart) is absent from UK results. Three named UK liner fabricators can drop-ship.	£100-300 ads to a planning-pack page; kit enquiries are the success metric
3	Fire pit replacement bowls & grates Spun-steel bowls in three diameters at £49/£69/£89	Page 1 contains whole fire pits, wrong-product grates, a forum thread asking where to buy, and a hacked domain. Four UK metal spinners with bowl tooling sit off-SERP.	£400-500 ads on 'fire pit replacement bowl' phrasings

Second tier, also live and testable: home charcuterie curing chambers (hardware only), hidden bookcase door kits, curved cabinet glass, and pool table re-cloth kits. A further eight cheap probes are specified inside. All first-tier tests together cost about £1,200.

The signature that separates the living from the dead

Every survivor shows the same page-1 pattern: the buyer's search is answered by something that is not the product. An installer where people want a kit. A US site where people want UK delivery. A forum where people want a checkout. A whole fire pit where people want the bowl. This is exactly what 'golf club weights' looked like before golfweights.co.uk existed, and it is now the primary scan criterion. Weak competitors on page 1 is not a signal; the wrong thing on page 1 is.

How the ideas were found

Keyword tools were demoted to sanity checks only, because they can only show demand that existing sellers have already shaped. Golf weights would never surface from keyword research. Two ideation lenses replaced them.

Lens 1: supply-side patterns

The five shapes behind the known successes: the unbundled part (golf weights), the trade product civilians want (lifebuoys), the byproduct (raw dog food), the borrowed range (the coffee brand), and the only-part-they-need (shepherd hut wheels). This lens produced the fire pit bowls, curved glass and re-cloth kit finds.

Lens 2: the pursuits of high earners

Map where affluent people spend on marginal improvement or the expression of taste, then look inside each pursuit for a category with no proper UK seller. Pursuits scanned: golf practice at home, kamado and outdoor-kitchen culture, home charcuterie and curing, sauna and cold-water culture, natural swimming, Hyrox and endurance (including altitude training), field sports (stalking, driven shoots, gundogs), equestrian smallholdings, sailing classes and rowing, astronomy, wine cellars, piano ownership, topiary and estate gardening, home libraries and hidden rooms. This lens produced the putting green, swim pond, curing chamber, hidden door and shoot-day finds.

The three gates

The shelf test: live Google UK page 1, not cached tool data. 3-4+ dedicated retail options for the exact product kills the idea; entering would mean a pricing battle. **The supplier test:** a named UK maker or wholesaler who could fulfil, is not on page 1, and would plausibly do the making while we own brand and channel. **The £2,000 test:** every surviving idea carries an ad-test spec under £500 so real demand is proven before anything is built.

Scale of the work

Around 150 raw ideas generated across both lenses; roughly 60 investigated in depth over five rounds; 80+ live page-1 checks run through eight parallel research tracks; 60+ off-SERP UK suppliers identified and named. The graveyard now holds around 45 evidenced kills.

What the scan taught us beyond the ideas

Windows close in two or three seasons. Sauna tents, Hyrox kit, padel infrastructure and golf simulator screens were all plausibly open in 2022-23; each now has 4-8 UK specialists. Whatever is trending visibly on Google is already colonised.

A foreign brand on UK page 1 is the best single leading indicator. XGrass on putting greens, Aquascape on swim ponds, Murphy Door and Invisidoor on hidden doors, Hypoxico on altitude kit: each marks demand that UK supply has not yet organised to meet, with freight and support friction protecting a local entrant.

Heavy DIY content marks the price-sensitive half of a market. Telescope piers looked open until the SERP showed 'build one for £100' videos filling half of page 1; that market builds rather than buys. Swim ponds show DIY content too, but with £3k-8k component spend attached, which is the profitable kind of DIY.

Scoreboard: the 37 ideas investigated in rounds 4-5

Verdicts: **LIVE** · **WEDGE** / **PROBE** · **DEAD**. Every verdict is from live Google UK results, August 2026. Named incumbents are given so nobody re-treads a dead angle.

Live

Idea	Verdict	Live page-1 evidence
Garden putting green DIY kits	LIVE	No UK kit seller. Installers, turf rolls, indoor mats and US XGrass substitute. Suppliers off-SERP: Nomow/Namgrass (Evergreens UK), TigerTurf, Consumer Grass.
Natural swimming pond kits	LIVE	One weak specialist (swimmingpondshop.co.uk); otherwise installers, a DIY course, US Aquascape. NaturaGart (DE) absent. Suppliers: Gordon Low, Aqualiners Direct, Russetts, Puddleplants.
Fire pit replacement bowls & grates	LIVE	Zero UK sellers; forum thread and hacked domain on page 1. Suppliers: Excell, Steel Spinnings, Tanfield, Metspin.
Home curing chambers (hardware only)	LIVE	SERP is DIY blogs, Reddit, wrong-product Amazon dryers, trade fridges. Gap between £40 controllers and £2k+ German Dry Agers. Suppliers: Angel Refrigeration, Corr Chilled, Inkbird. Consumables are off-limits (Weschenfelder, 2.6k reviews).
Hidden bookcase door kits	LIVE	Page 1 is a one-man joiner's Facebook page, a phone-only maker, one importer of US Invisidoor, Amazon hinges and DIY videos. Related searches show 'bookcase door kit uk'. Murphy Door (US) proves the category. Suppliers: CNC shops (Crocodile takes overflow), joineries. Adjacent threat: The Library Ladder Company.
Curved cabinet glass, productised	LIVE	US firms, forums and whole cabinets substitute; UK benders are quote-only trade. Suppliers: Runcorn, Arc, Intaglio, Lee Glass, Specialist Glass Products.
Pool & snooker DIY re-cloth kits	LIVE	Fitting services substitute for the kit; one dated specialist. Supply gated behind Peradon and the Milliken cloth mills.

Wedges and probes

Idea	Verdict	Live page-1 evidence
Shoot-day presentation equipment	WEDGE	'Gun stand shoot day' returns rifle rests; 'driven shoot equipment' returns clothing advice. Peg-number market proves buyers tolerate £150-440. Sellers hide in image packs only. Test in September pre-season.
Altitude training rental	WEDGE	One UK specialist; ~40% of page 1 is US, Belgian and Dutch. Sporting Edge (Basingstoke, European altitude-chamber leader) has no consumer offer and is a natural partner.
Single scull covers	WEDGE	~3 small UK sellers padded out by forums, Italian and US sites and unfitted tarps. Suppliers: Tecsew, Canvasman, Sail Register. Dinghy-class covers are dead (7-9 sellers).
Piano climate care, sold with fitting	PROBE	Occupied but fragmented across regional piano shops; nobody bundles product + booked tuner install. Distribution gettable via Fletcher & Newman.
Kamado Joe-specific tables	PROBE	Head term dead (6-7 sellers incl. the OEM) but the 'kamado joe table' phrasing is weakly served. £100 probe only.
Sauna accessories basket	PROBE	Tents are dead (4-5 UK specialists); stones, buckets and thermometer baskets are unowned. £100 probe.
Canine hoopers starter sets	PROBE	Governing body, a German shop and a Facebook group hold the SERP. Small but growing.
Allotment rainwater kit	PROBE	Bundle query returns only PDFs and forums; component market saturated. Kit angle only.
Branded sports matting	PROBE	Kept per earlier discussion as a hypothesis: mis-served SERP is real, demand case is guesswork, business case unclear. Cheap quote-page test only.
Caravan locker keys & catches	PROBE	Still unvalidated; two-day check before any spend.

Dead, with the named incumbents

Idea	Verdict	Live page-1 evidence
Golf simulator screens & enclosures	DEAD	6+ UK specialists (GolfBays SimBox stocked by four retailers); Carl's Place window closed 2-3 years ago.
Hyrox home training kit	DEAD	Official Centr licensee plus dealer network (Wolverson, BLK BOX, Bulldog, Mirafit) and Amazon.
Kamado tables (head terms)	DEAD	6-7 dedicated sellers including Big Green Egg UK itself.
Sauna tents	DEAD	Runitude, Bell Tent Sussex, Roman Oasis, Banana Industries, Outbacker plus Amazon. Nordic imports already landed.
Deer larder equipment & high seats	DEAD	Monarch, BDS shop, Bushwear (on all three SERPs), Devana, Keith's, Fisher.
Paddock care machinery	DEAD	Trafalgar #1 on two of three queries plus SCH, Wessex, Logic, Chapman, Paddock Blade.
Topiary frames & estate wirework	DEAD	Top Topiary owns both SERPs; Agrumi, Black Country Metalworks, Amazon, eBay; supports have 6 specialists.
Dinghy covers by class	DEAD	7-9 dedicated options per SERP including two covermakers (Rain & Sun, UK Custom Covers).
Telescope piers & observatory kit	DEAD	Pulsar and Altair through the FLO/RVO/Widescreen dealer network; half of page 1 is 'build it for £100' DIY.
Wine cellar cooling	DEAD	Wineware (707 reviews), Elite Fridges, EuroCave direct, Heron Hill, Wine Corner, Hawco: 6-8 per SERP.
Library ladders	DEAD	The Library Ladder Company holds three top-ten slots plus Ladderstore and Ramsay.
Garden bench slats / bed slats / parasol & gazebo canopies	DEAD	7-8, 3 and 5+ dedicated specialists respectively; the #1 bed-slat seller is the UK manufacturer.
IBC fittings / hen consumables / wool garden products / smoking wood	DEAD	Each has 4-8 dedicated options; wool and smoking wood incumbents already executed the byproduct play (Chimney Sheep; Gwernyfed sawmill).
Campervan furniture kits / dog agility / horse jumps / green roof kits / hearths / fly-tying / pigeon consumables	DEAD	8+, 7+, 5-8, 6-7, 8+, 10+, 7-8 dedicated options respectively; sedum growers and game-byproduct sellers already went direct.
Swing seat parts / cast iron bench ends	DEAD	Two specialists each plus marketplaces (side-checks).

Rounds 1-3 kills (garage door spares, greenhouse spares, netting, vee belts, arena mirrors, cricket covers, changing benches, padel canopies, blind spares, derailleur hangers, stove glass, hot tub filters and others) are documented in the project workbook and git history. Hot tub filters was withdrawn on economics: a £12 product on a shelf Amazon already stocks deep.

Business case 1: Garden putting green DIY kits

The product. A complete home putting green in a box: pro-grade putting surface cut to size, regulation 108mm cups, flags, fringe turf, edging, fixings and an install video, in three sizes. Starter 3x2m around £499, mid 5x3m around £999, large 8x4m around £1,999. The buyer is the golf-weights buyer ten years on: money, obsession, and a lawn.

Why the shelf is empty

Installers want £3,000-15,000 jobs and rank for the kit terms with service pages. Turf sellers sell rolls at £14-50/m² with no cups, base or edging. Amazon serves indoor mats. XGrass, a US kit maker, ranks on UK page 1 for both kit phrasings with a product nobody ships here. Seven of nine organic results for 'artificial putting green diy' are forums and videos: unserved buyers teaching each other. B&Q's £349 boxed green is the only kit-shaped object in the market and it is a toy.

Supplier (not on page 1)	What they'd supply
Evergreens UK Group (Nomow / Namgrass)	UK manufacturer/distributor of putting-grade turf, trade-focused, no retail kit
TigerTurf UK	Sports-turf manufacturer with a golf range, B2B only
Forever Green Lawns / Consumer Grass	Trade and wholesale artificial grass supply

Economics and sizing, assumptions stated

Trade putting turf runs £8-15/m² against £25-35/m² retail; cups, flags and edging are commodity; assume 45-55% gross margin on kits after pallet freight (the heavy-kit freight is the main cost to quote properly). Value anchors: installs start at £3,000, so a £999 kit is the obvious middle. Ten kits a month at £900 average is £9k/mo revenue; the ceiling is set by how much of the installer market converts to DIY. Caveats: spring-summer seasonal, bulky returns need a policy, installers could bolt on kits if the niche becomes visible, and base preparation is the hard part for buyers, so the guide content is the real product. Strategic fit is unusually good: the agency already knows the UK golf search landscape from the golfweights work, and the content engine (practice guides, green-speed content) is the same muscle.

The £300 test

One kit-configurator landing page (three sizes, one hero image each, base-prep guide teased). £300 Google Ads on exact and phrase 'putting green kit uk', 'diy putting green kit', 'garden putting green kit'. Nobody owns the exact terms, so clicks should be cheap. Success: 2%+ conversion to order or £40 per qualified enquiry on the large size. Fulfil the first kits by buying trade turf cut to order before committing to stock.

Business case 2: Natural swimming pond kits

The product. Staged self-build kits for swimming ponds on larger plots. Entry: a £99-299 planning pack (design templates, liner calculator, planting schedule, a consultation call). Core: component kits at £3k-8k combining a box-welded EPDM liner made to the customer's dimensions, pump and filtration module, and regeneration-zone plant collections, drop-shipped by the fabricator and nursery. The buyer owns land, wants wild swimming at home, and is currently bouncing between YouTube and £50k+ installer quotes.

Why the shelf is nearly empty

One dedicated UK kit seller exists (swimmingpondshop.co.uk) and holds the top slots thinly. Everything else on three buyer queries is installers, a DIY course (Organic Pools), YouTube, generic small-pond kits, wrong products and forums. Aquascape (US) ranks for 'swim pond kit' with no UK offer, and NaturaGart, the German company that industrialised this exact self-build kit model in Europe, is absent from UK page 1 entirely. The wild-swimming and garden-wellness trends supply the demand tailwind.

Supplier (not on page 1)	What they'd supply
Gordon Low Products	50 years of bespoke box-welded Butyl/EPDM liners, made to dimensions
Aqualiners Direct / Russetts Developments	Alternative made-to-shape liner fabricators
Puddleplants / Waterside Nursery	Aquatic plant nurseries for regeneration-zone planting packs

Economics and sizing, assumptions stated

Broker-plus-kit model: liner and pumps drop-shipped at an assumed 25-40% margin, planting packs at 50%+, planning packs nearly pure margin. Two component kits a month at £4,000 average is £8k/mo revenue before the planning-pack layer. Caveats, and they are real: long consideration cycles, seasonal (plan in winter, build in spring), support-heavy pre-sale, water-safety liability language needed, and excavation is genuinely hard, which is why the planning pack comes first: it monetises the research phase we would otherwise be doing for free, and builds the enquiry list for kits.

The £100-300 test

Publish the planning pack and one kit page. £100-300 ads on 'swimming pond kit', 'natural swimming pool kit uk', 'swim pond cost' phrasings. Success: planning-pack sales at under £20 CPA, or 10+ qualified kit enquiries. The pack revenue partially refunds the test.

Business case 3: Fire pit replacement bowls & grates (carried from round 4)

Unchanged and still the cheapest, fastest test on the list. Three spun-steel diameters at £49/£69/£89 plus laser-cut grates; page 1 currently offers a forum thread, a hacked domain and the wrong products; Excell, Steel Spinnings, Tanfield and Metspin can spin bowls on existing tooling. Assumed landed cost £18-30, margin 45-60%, sharply seasonal March-August. The £400-500 ad test on 'fire pit replacement bowl' phrasings proves or kills it in a month; the measured-fit guide is the moat if it works.

Second-tier cases, shorter form

Idea	Offer & supplier route	Economics	Test & risks
Home curing chamber kits	Fridge-conversion kit (Inkbird temp + humidity controllers, humidifier, guide) at £149-249, and a converted glass-door chamber at £799-999. Base fridges from Corr Chilled/Nextday; Angel Refrigeration for white-label. Stay out of consumables (Weschenfelder owns them).	Kit margin 50%+; chamber margin 30-40%. Buyer already spends £100+ on meat per batch.	£100-250 ads on 'meat curing chamber uk', 'curing fridge kit'. Risks: food-safety guidance must be careful and content-led; German Dry Ager could go downmarket.
Hidden bookcase door kits	UK-made pivot-hardware + carcass kit at £600-1,500, flat-packed, fitted by any chippy. CNC route: Crocodile (Swindon) takes overflow production; joinery partners plentiful. Murphy Door (US) proves the category at \$1.5-3k.	Assumed build cost £250-500/kit; 45-55% margin. Home-office and media-room trend supplies demand.	£250 ads on 'bookcase door kit uk', 'hidden door kit'. Risks: The Library Ladder Company is adjacent and could extend; fitting complexity needs a good template pack.
Curved cabinet glass	Fixed-price online flow ('3 photos + a template, quote in 48h, from £149') brokered to Runcorn/Arc/Intaglio benders.	30-50% broker margin on £150-450 jobs; ten jobs/mo is £2.5k revenue.	£300 ads; success is sub-£15 cost per quote request. Risks: transit breakage (packaging is the hard problem), template errors, bespoke lead times.
Pool table re-cloth kits	Sized kit (cloth + rubber + tools + video) at £119-179 from Peradon trade components; fitting services currently substitute at £125+.	50-60% margin at assumed £45-70 component cost.	£300 ads on 'pool table recloth kit'. Risks: DIY skill floor means support load; incumbent could modernise.

Probes, one line each

Probe	Test
Shoot-day presentation range	£300 Search + Shopping in September on peg/stand/gift terms against an engraved-oak presentation range; estate joiners fulfil. Wrong products (rifle rests) currently rank.
Altitude training rental	£300 on 'altitude tent hire uk'; partner conversation with Sporting Edge (Basingstoke) in parallel.
Single scull covers	£300 on 'single scull cover' to a fitment page; Tecsew or Sail Register sew to pattern.
Piano care with fitting bundled	£250 on 'piano humidifier' against a product-plus-booked-tuner page; distribution via Fletcher & Newman.
Kamado Joe tables / sauna accessories / hoopers / allotment rain kit	£100-250 each, exact-match phrasings only, as specified in the scoreboard.
Branded sports matting (hypothesis)	£300-500 to a portfolio-and-quote page; retained because the test is cheap, not because the case is proven.

Recommended sequence

When	Action	Cost
Week 1	Putting green kits: quotes from Evergreens UK and TigerTurf; configurator page; £300 ad test live	Under £500
Week 1-2	Fire pit bowls: spinning quotes (Excell, Steel Spinings, Tanfield); one-page store; £400-500 test	Under £700
Week 2-3	Swim ponds: planning pack written; liner conversation with Gordon Low; £100-300 test	Under £400
Week 3+	Second tier as appetite allows: curing chambers, hidden door kits, curved glass, re-cloth kits (each under £600 all-in)	Optional
September	Shoot-day presentation probe, timed to pre-season	£300
Ongoing	Monthly wrong-thing-on-page-1 scan; watch the foreign-brand indicator; revisit robot mower blades and padel consumables each spring	An hour a month

The three first-tier tests together cost about £1,200, inside the £2,000 ceiling, and each returns a clean keep-or-kill answer within 4-6 weeks. Nothing gets built until an ad test pays for itself in orders or qualified enquiries.

Method and data appendix

Sources: live Google UK results via SERPAPI (80+ pulls across the project, run through eight parallel research tracks in rounds 4-5), supplier discovery via manufacturer directories, trade bodies and company sites (60+ off-SERP UK suppliers named), Ahrefs demoted to sanity checks. **Caveats:** costs and margins in the business cases are assumptions awaiting quotes and are labelled as such; market-volume figures are industry estimates; live SERPs change, so re-check before spending; earlier rounds found AI-generated keyword families inflating several niches, so raw keyword exports should not be trusted without cleaning. **Companion files:** Niche-Product-Longlist.xlsx (rounds 1-3 data and graveyard) and prior report versions in git history.